



carried on a bicycle in 1966 (left); the LVM3-M4 launch vehicle being transported in 2023

that same ethos of frugality and pragmatism. That was made amply clear by Isro Chairman S. Somanath at the Indian Space Congress in July this year.

“India, especially, is a country where if you like giving it [for] free, it’s very good. You will be building a huge business. But then, of course, there needs to be a business model,” he told a cross-section of stakeholders. A strong proponent of taking satellite communications to the masses, Somanath has been pushing hard to also make the technology affordable. “We have to find ways through which on-ground infrastructure and connectivity are actually delivered to people in millions at an extremely low cost.”

The satellite internet market is expected to touch a 27 per cent share of the global space industry by 2040, a massive increase over its current share of less than 1 per cent, according to a Deloitte study. Moreover, satellite manufacturing, satellite launch, commercial human spaceflight and commercial remote

sensing are also likely to gain substantially. Crucially, the government spending component, that has been considerable all these years, is expected to fall from 27 per cent in 2021 to less than 18 per cent by 2040. Isro will cede space to the private sector to drive future growth.

GUIDED BY ALTRUISM

Although often touted as the world’s lowest cost yet most successful space agency, contrary to popular belief Isro has never been managed as a company as it always worked with a somewhat altruistic agenda. For instance, the revenue earned from foreign and domestic satellite launches would earlier go into the Department of Space’s (DoS) balance sheet. After NewSpace India Ltd (NSIL) was formed in 2019, it takes care of all commercial activities after buying ready-made assets and services from Isro. That money makes its way to the balance sheet of the DoS, which in turn funds Isro. NSIL is a profitable entity—in FY22, it recorded profit

THE ISRO STORY

FOUNDED 1969. Has its roots in the Indian National Committee for Space Research (INCOSPAR)

POSITION World’s sixth-largest space agency

STRENGTHS Built a strong position across the value chain of satellite communications, earth observation, satellite navigation, launch vehicles, and space and science exploration

LAUNCHES 125 spacecraft missions and 92 launch missions

FOREIGN LAUNCHES 431 satellites for 34 countries since 1999. In the past five years, the agency has earned \$94 million from such launches

NSIL Established in 2019 to market products and services as well as enable technology transfers from Isro

SPACEPORT Satish Dhawan Space Centre (SDSC), Sriharikota (Andhra Pradesh)



S. SOMANATH
CHAIRMAN, ISRO

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